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‘AN AWFUL, AWFUL SMELL’

Excessive odors, landfill fires are next round in Southeast Side’s battle against pollution

By Finnegan Belleau
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Oscar Ortega likes to sit out on his porch in South Deering and watch cars go by. He did, at least, before the smell.

“When we moved here, my wife actually liked the scenery,” Ortega said. “It looks like a small-town scenery, you know, just a few houses, lots of trees. But then something just slapped us right in the face: the odor.”

His house is next to Pullman Innovations, a facility that creates ingredients used in animal feed. And since management changed a decade ago, Ortega, 59, said pungent smells on days the plant operates have prevented him from going outside or opening the windows.

On Aug. 5, Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul and the city of Chicago sued A-F Acquisition LLC, which operates under the name Pullman Innovations. The lawsuit alleged that the company allowed excessive odors, caused illegal air pollution, constructed a boiler without a permit that could cause or contribute to air pollution, and violated certain conditions of the operating permit at its Chicago facility, according to a news release.

Two days later, the attorney general issued another news release announcing a lawsuit against three companies alleging they endangered the environment and public safety by allowing fires to break out at the Harbor View waste facility, a closed landfill site

about 4 miles from Pullman Innovations.

The Southeast Side has long dealt with industrial pollution and environmental justice issues, but in recent years residents won two major victories.

Approval for a metal shredding plant in the community went back and forth in court before being blocked in 2024 amid outcry from residents and activists. After yearslong litigation with community groups and resistance from the state environmental agency, the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers dropped its plan to expand a toxic waste dump along the Lake Michigan shoreline in 2025.

Gina Ramirez, director of Midwest environmental health at the Natural Resources Defense Council, lives in East Side, several miles away from the fires. Even so, she said it still smelled like a forest fire near her home and the community for about a week.

Ramirez said there’s a lot of “finger-pointing” by companies claiming they aren’t responsible for foul odors or soil pollution. The onus often seems to be on community members to prove otherwise, but she said this can be difficult for Southeast Side residents struggling to make ends meet and find the time for such efforts.

Ramirez said government entities need to step up. “It shouldn’t fall on the community to be constantly doing this,” she said.

The Illinois Environmental Protection Agency referred the



Top: The Pullman Innovations plant sits just a few blocks from residential buildings on the Southeast Side of Chicago on Tuesday. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Above: Oscar Ortega, who lives near Pullman Innovations, looks west from his home toward the facility on Monday as he discusses his class-action lawsuit and the odors emitting from the nearby plant. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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NASCAR won’t race in Chicago in 2027

Organization confirms it will put Joliet back on schedule next summer

By Robert Channick
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The streets of Grant Park will not echo with the sounds of 200 mph race cars in 2027.

Running out of time to strike a deal with the city, NASCAR pulled the plug Tuesday on the return of the Chicago Street Race for next summer, but is still hoping to bring it back down the road.

Meanwhile, NASCAR confirmed it is putting Chicagoland Speedway in Joliet back on the schedule again next summer after a successful return to the long-idled southwest suburban track over July Fourth weekend.

NASCAR had been hoping to get both Chicago and Joliet on track for 2027.

“While we will not be racing on the streets of Chicago in 2027 despite genuine joint efforts by both NASCAR and our partners at the city and state level, we remain committed to the Chicagoland region and would welcome the opportunity to bring the NASCAR Chicago Street Race back at some point in the future,” NASCAR said in a statement.

The Chicago Street Race, which turned Grant Park into a pop-up urban racecourse over July Fourth weekend from 2023 to 2025, went on hiatus this year while NASCAR and the city explored ways to minimize disruption and maximize

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President pushes plan for forests

Proposal would open 45M acres of pristine areas to development

By Lisa Friedman
and Maxine Joselow
THE NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration on Tuesday advanced a plan to open nearly 45 million acres of wilderness in national forests to road construction and logging, removing protections that had been in place for a quarter century.

The proposal by the U.S. Forest Service would repeal the 2001 “roadless rule,” enacted during the Clinton administration to preserve the wild nature of forest land. It comes as President Donald Trump pressures the agency to increase logging and to thin forests to prevent wildfires.

The repeal would hand a major victory to Republican-led states and industry groups that have argued for years that the prohibitions have hindered economic development. More than a dozen lawsuits have unsuccessfully sought to strike down the rule.

During his first term, Trump stripped protections from Alaska’s Tongass National Forest, the largest intact temperate rainforest in the world, only for the Biden admin-

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DJ and husband released from ICE custody, but fight not over

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Local DJ and rising star Omar David Panqueva, who goes by the stage name DJ TUNJO, and his husband, Santiago Páez, have been released from Immigration and Customs Enforcement custody on bond. But their legal fight to stay in the United States is far from over.

Panqueva, 26, and Páez, 27, of Colombia, were arrested by ICE agents at Midway International Airport on Aug. 2, where they were set to board a flight to the nation’s capital, then to follow reggaeton superstar Karol G’s tour across the country to DJ a series of unofficial after-parties.

Now, after being released on Aug. 12, the tour and their careers are on pause as they fight to obtain legal status in the United States. While it’s possible for DJ TUNJO to headline more Karol G after-parties, it’s uncertain.

“This is our city. We moved here because this is our safe space. We were reborn here in many ways,” said Panqueva, who was seeking asylum with his husband because of the persecution they faced in Colombia as members of the LGBTQ+ community. “We have a big community here that we are always looking to give back to, to do things for. So for us seeing

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Omar David Panqueva, known as DJ TUNJO, left, and his husband, Santiago Páez, at Galeria Chicago on Tuesday. The Colombian couple was detained by immigration agents at Midway International Airport earlier this month while beginning a multicity tour to DJ after-parties in tandem with Colombian pop star Karol G’s tour. Panqueva regularly performs at Galeria Chicago. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Fillin’ the villain role

S&C 20 years after A.J. Pierzynski became a City Series villain, Pete Crow-Armstrong steps into the void. On Monday, he walked off a historic night as the Cubs beat the Sox 7-5 in 10 innings. **Sports**

Google loosens political filter

The company has quietly rolled out a program that will allow candidates, political parties and political action committees to more easily send fundraising appeals and bypass Gmail’s spam filter. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Not your grandma’s galbi

Mister Tiger, a Korean restaurant in Chicago’s West Town neighborhood that opened in May 2025 as an ode to a grandmother’s home cooking, has become a new chef’s culinary coming of age. **Food & Health**

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